possible help as and when the situation demanded. This kind of planning process involving the three services of a country was quite unprecedented in contemporary UN history, and it helped in enhancing our image in the region and the world. It most certainly had an effect on the belligerents in Somalia and they did not mess around much with our force thereafter.

My promotion board was held during 1995–96, and I was approved to take over a division as a two-star general. As I had not served in Western Command for almost twenty years, I wrote to the military secretary if he could consider posting me to command any formation in the western theatre, so that I could gain the required experience. My request was acceded to and my appointment as the GOC of 9 Infantry Division was announced in June 1996.

9 Infantry Division was a part of Indian 3 Corps during the Second World War. It took part in operations against the Japanese in Malaya. Finally, it was merged with 2 Indian Division and fought in the battle of Singapore Island. This division was re-raised in August 1964 by Major General P.S. Bhagat, VC, at Saugor, as a result of the expansion of the Indian Army after the 1962 war. It was converted into a mountain division and was moved to Ranchi. Major General Prem Bhagat, the only Indian officer to be awarded the Victoria Cross for outstanding bravery during the Second World War, was a dynamic leader. He forged the division into a highly motivated team with well-set operational drills and procedures. The division has a symbol of a pine tree in its formation badge, and hence is also referred to as the pine division. During the Indo-Pak war of 1971, the division fought extremely well under the leadership of Major General Dalbir Singh, and won the battle honour of Jessore. Several of its brave officers and men were decorated with gallantry awards. Later, the division moved to Meerut, near Delhi. So, I did not have far to go, and took over the formation from Major General K.G. Pitre in July 1996.

My foremost aim was also to forge a war-winning team, and enhance esprit de corps. I got my formation commanders and staff